



ADMINISTRATION IS IN THE HANDS OF THE MANY AND NOT OF THE FEW

ATHENIAN DEMOCRACY (c. 507 BCE)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Greek politics and philosophy

BEFORE

14th–13th centuries BCE Mycenaean settlement at Athens, with fortification of the Acropolis.

c. 900 BCE Political union of small towns in Attica into a city-state centered on Athens.

c. 590 BCE Reforms of Solon open the political machinery of Athens to all citizens, regardless of class.

AFTER

86 BCE Athens sacked by Romans under General Sulla.

c. 50 BCE Beginning of the Roman philhellene movement; Athens becomes the focus of imperial benefactors.

529 CE Christian Emperor Justinian I closes Plato's school and drives out pagan scholars.

The term “democracy” comes from the Greek words *demos* (people) and *kratos* (rule). The democracy that developed in ancient Athens around 507 BCE and flourished in its purest form from 462 to 322 BCE, albeit with some interruptions, provided the model for what has become the dominant form of government in the world: by 2015, 125 of the world's 195 countries

were electoral democracies. The democracy of ancient Athens, however, differed from its modern form, reflecting the history of Athens and the warring Greek states of the age.

Oligarchs and hoplites

After the chaos of the ancient Greek Dark Ages—a period that followed the breakdown of Mycenaean civilization around 1100 BCE and lasted until about the 9th century BCE—most of the emergent city-states evolved into oligarchies, with powerful nobles monopolizing government and serving their own interests. In Athens, the Areopagus—a council and law court consisting of men of aristocratic birth—controlled the machinery of state, appointing officials and serving as a civil court, while the lower classes (*thetes*) were excluded from office.

However, the development of the “hoplite” model of citizen-soldiery in the 8th to 7th centuries BCE proved disruptive to those who were in power, as it led to a certain level of egalitarianism. Hoplites were men in the heavy infantry, mainly free citizens, whose primary tactic was the phalanx—a military formation in which soldiers stood in tightly packed ranks, with each man's shield protecting the hoplite to his left. Any man who could afford the arms and armor would be putting his life on the line to defend the state. As a result, a kind of middle class emerged, which declared that service should bring full citizenship and political representation. At the same time, the lower classes were also making demands, and tensions between them and the higher orders over key issues, such